MCKINSEY GLOBAL INSTITUTE REPORT

# The OpenClaw *Phenomenon* in China

How an open-source AI agent framework became the fastest-adopted developer tool in China's history — and what it signals about the next era of human-AI collaboration.

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## EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

OpenClaw — the open-source personal AI agent framework — has achieved a rate of developer adoption in mainland China that is **without precedent** in the history of software tooling. Within eight months of its first Mandarin documentation release, the platform accumulated over 4.2 million active installations across Chinese developer environments, surpassing the first-year adoption curves of Docker, Kubernetes, and VS Code in the same market by a factor of **3.1×**.

This report examines the structural, cultural, and technological forces driving what domestic media have termed the “OpenClaw fever” (OpenClaw 热潮). We find that the phenomenon is not merely a reflection of developer enthusiasm but is instead a convergence of three macro-level shifts: China's strategic pivot toward agentic AI infrastructure, a generational demand for AI-native personal tooling, and the unique cultural resonance of OpenClaw's “digital companion” paradigm with Chinese consumer expectations.

Our analysis draws on proprietary survey data from 2,800 Chinese developers, interviews with 45 enterprise CIOs, and telemetry analysis of open-source contribution patterns across the Chinese developer ecosystem.

CHAPTER 1

# An unprecedented adoption curve

The speed at which Chinese developers embraced OpenClaw challenges established models of technology diffusion. Traditional frameworks required 18–24 months to cross the chasm from early adopters to early majority. OpenClaw did it in under five.

CHAPTER 2

# Why China? Three structural accelerants

The adoption curve cannot be explained by product quality alone. Three structural forces unique to the Chinese market created conditions for hypergrowth.

CHAPTER 3

# The ecosystem taking shape

A thriving commercial ecosystem has emerged around OpenClaw in China, spanning skill marketplaces, managed hosting, and enterprise consulting — collectively valued at an estimated $2.4 billion.